

"peace and security". This was taken to mean that India was willing to discuss Kashmir and even Balochistan.

Pakistan, which till then had been demanding that India resume any form of dialogue, began to play hardball. Its game seemed to be to push India into resumption of the composite dialogue, thus taking it off the hook on terrorism. This would blot out its alleged complicity in Mumbai's 26/11 attacks which saw India suspend all talks with Pakistan till they took credible action in booking the perpetrators and dismantling the terror infrastructure in their territory. Pakistan Foreign Minister Shah Mahmood Qureshi even went ballistic against India at a meeting in Multan, saying that "the same forces that were threatening to attack Pakistan post-26/11 were now issuing invitations for peace talks". He then rubbed it in, saying, "India has come to us and sought talks. We never kneeled and did not bow to their pressure."

The offer for talks by India at this juncture has come in for criticism from some experts. G. Parthasarathy, a former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan, believes that it "is ill-timed and has made India look like a supplicant. It's given Pakistan the feeling that we are batting on a sticky wicket. India has lost the initiative and is allowing Pakistan to set the agenda." Brahma Chellaney, strategic analyst, is as critical, stating, "The latest initiative seeks to take off from where the Sharm el-Sheikh action ran aground. That is why, once again, New Delhi has delinked talks with Islamabad from Pakistani action against terrorism." The MEA though maintains that too much should not be read into the offer. As one official said: "We only wanted to unlock the halt in the process. We will insist on terrorism being the core issue. Mind you, this is only a first step and whether it leads to a process is to be seen."

So why is India resuming talks with Pakistan? In reality, India and Pakistan have never stopped talking. Apart from a summit meeting, the foreign ministers have met thrice. Most of these meetings saw India demanding that Pakistan take "credible" action against terror and a defensive Pakistan plead-

ing inability. Pakistan then was facing a wave of militant attacks and the Government had run into major turmoil with the Supreme Court questioning the legitimacy of Asif Zardari's presidency. The army under General Ashfaq Kayani was trying to regain dominance after the ignominious exit of Pervez Musharraf. Manmohan had then said, "We don't know who we should be talking to in Pakistan."

There now appear to be multiple factors that have triggered the latest initiative that in all probability may lead to the resumption of a formal dialogue process. Top on the list was the London Conference on Afghanistan, where India despite its goodwill diplomacy in Kabul, seemed out of sync with international opinion. India continued with its stand that it was against negotiating with the Taliban and bringing them back to the political mainstream in Afghanistan, with Foreign Minister S. M. Krishna saying: "There is no such thing as good or bad Taliban; they only seem to know the language of terrorism." But the Pakistan argument that the "good" Taliban leaders were a part of the Afghan solution seemed to have

## PAKISTAN'S PLAN

### WHY NOW?

It was surprised at the Indian offer for talks, but is keen for a dialogue as engaging with India lends credibility to the civilian regime in Pakistan.

### WHAT WILL IT DO?

Pakistan will use the dialogue process to bring the focus back on Kashmir and highlight the Balochistan issue which it managed to get on the talks menu at Sharm el-Sheikh.

### THE BIG WORRY

India may use the dialogue to flatten Pakistan's campaign that India was being cussed. With Kashmir stabilising, talks may not yield much; Pakistan may have to take real steps on terror.

